ATLAS DESK · CHESS FOLDER

Chess Field Guide

Meet the six pieces, then learn the rules with a picture for each one. Goes with the episode "Chess for beginners." Print it, cut out the cards, and quiz each other at the table.

MEET THE ARMY



THE KING
a.k.a. The Boss

POINTS	ON THE BOARD
The game	1 per side



Moves: One square, any direction.

Power: Castling: once a game he tucks into the corner behind a rook.

Watch out: Slow, and he can never step into check.

Raja in India, the Shah in Persia; "shah mat" became checkmate.



THE QUEEN
a.k.a. The Powerhouse

POINTS	ON THE BOARD
9	1 per side



Moves: Straight or diagonal, as far as she wants.

Power: Rook and bishop in one piece.

Watch out: Too valuable to lose cheap. Don't bring her out early.

Started as the weakest piece, one step diagonally. Spain made her strong in the 1400s.



THE ROOK
a.k.a. The Bulldozer

POINTS	ON THE BOARD
5	2 per side



Moves: Straight lines: forward, back, left, right.

Power: Owns open lines. Castling partner for the king.

Watch out: Stuck in the corner until the pawns move.

Ratha, the chariot, in India.



THE BISHOP
a.k.a. The Long Shot

POINTS	ON THE BOARD
3	2 per side



Moves: Diagonals, as far as it wants.

Power: Hits from across the whole board.

Watch out: Stays on one color forever.

Gaja, the elephant, in India.



THE KNIGHT
a.k.a. The Jumper

POINTS	ON THE BOARD
3	2 per side



Moves: An L: two squares one way, one to the side.

Power: The only piece that jumps. Always lands on the other color.

Watch out: Slow to cross the board.

Ashva, the horse, in India.



THE PAWN
a.k.a. The Little Soldier

POINTS	ON THE BOARD
1	8 per side



Moves: Forward one (two on its first move). Captures one square diagonally forward.

Power: Promotion: reach the far side and become a queen.

Watch out: Never goes backward.

Padati, the foot soldier, in India.

Blue dots: squares the piece can move to. Blue ring: a piece it can capture.

POINTS

Pawn **1**

Knight **3**

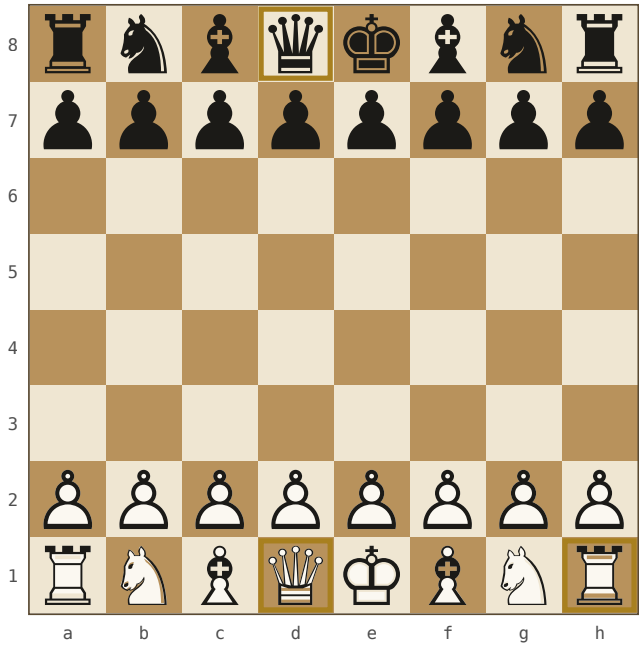
Bishop **3**

Rook **5**

Queen **9**

King **the whole game**

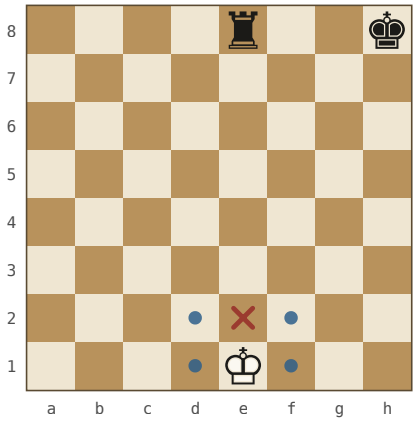
1 · SET UP THE BOARD



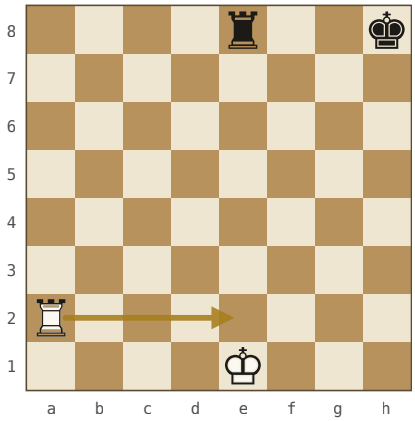
Light square on the right (gold box, h1). Rooks in the corners, then knights, then bishops. The queen goes on her own color (gold boxes, d1 and d8); the king takes the last square. White moves first.

2 · CHECK, AND THE THREE WAYS OUT

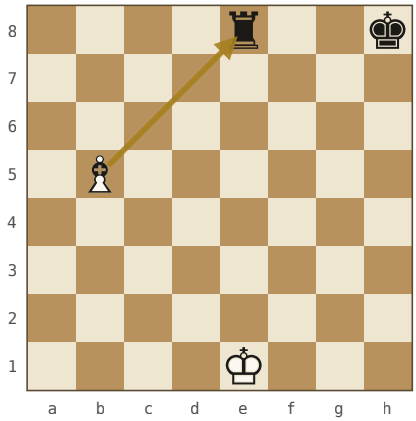
The black rook on e8 attacks the white king on e1. That's check. White must fix it on this move.



Move it. Step to a blue square. The e-file is still under attack (red X).

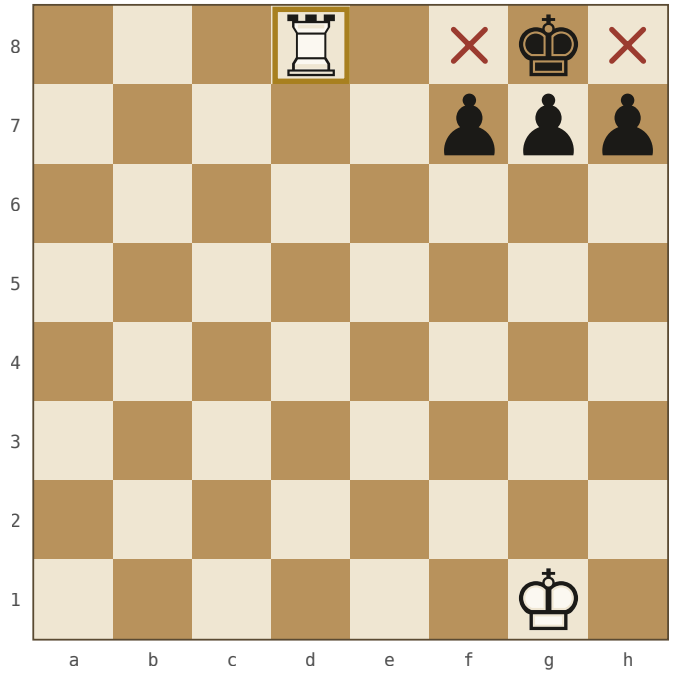


Block it. Slide the rook to e2, between the attacker and the king.

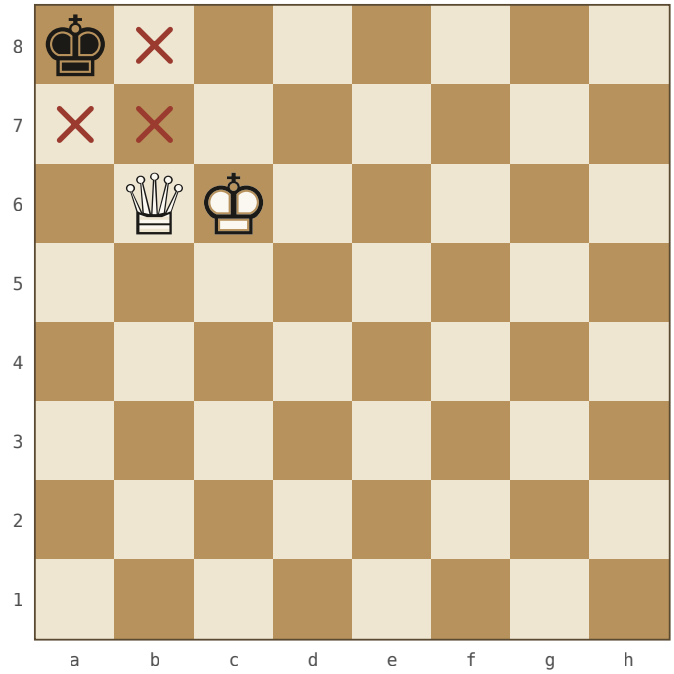


Take it. The bishop on b5 captures the rook on e8.

3 · CHECKMATE AND STALEMATE

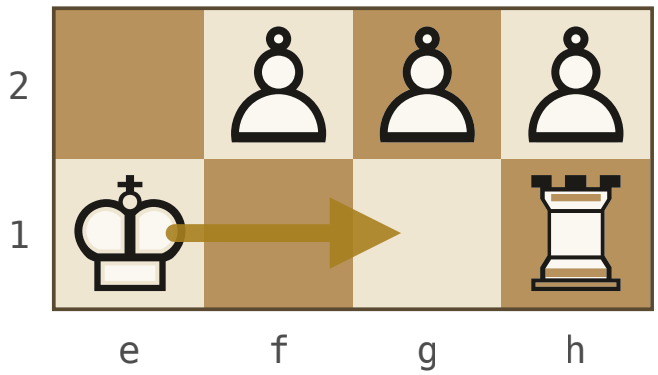


Checkmate. The rook on d8 attacks the king along the back row. f8 and h8 are attacked, and his own pawns block the rest. No move, no block, no capture: game over.

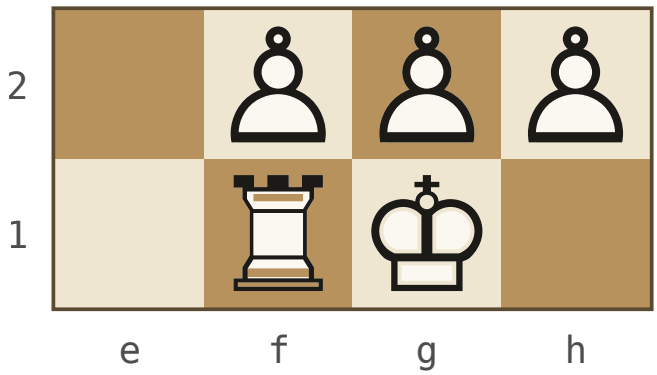


Stalemate. Black to move. The king on a8 is not in check, but every square around him is covered (red X) and he has no other piece. No legal move means a draw, even if White is way ahead.

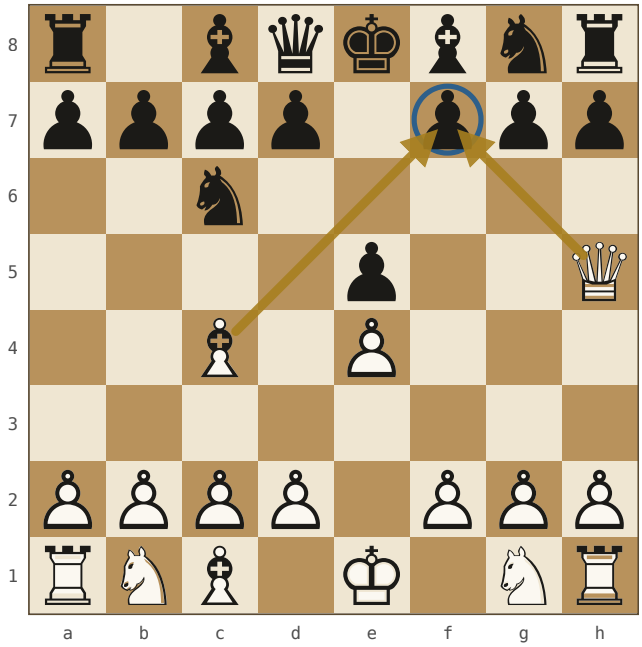
4 · CASTLING



Before: king on e1, rook on h1, nothing between them, neither has moved.



After: the king slides two squares to g1 and the rook hops over to f1. Not allowed if the king is in check or would cross or land on an attacked square.



After 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5, the queen and the bishop both aim at f7, a square only the king guards. If Black ignores it (3...Nf6?), Qxf7 is checkmate. Stop it with 3...g6 or 3...Qe7. Then chase that early queen while you bring your pieces out.

Before every move: what does my opponent want?

Then check for checks, captures and threats. In the opening: a pawn in the middle, knights and bishops out, castle.